

# Smartphone OS Wars:

## Searching for the *one* perfect smartphone OS

Handset manufacturers are vying for market dominance and aren't leaving any stone unturned in convincing you of their advantage over others. How do you make the right decision?

Vishal Mathur  
vishal.mathur@thinkdigit.com

In the good old days, Symbian was the smartphone operating system of choice; in fact, people didn't bother remembering the name. The rest were dumb-phones! Fast forward to the present day. The scenario is totally different. For someone who has not followed the developments in this arena, it is close to unbelievable.

Nokia's Symbian has been truly overshadowed by a several smartphone OSes. Apple's very popular iPhone (iOS), Google's Android and the 'made for business' Blackberry OS are now ruling the roost. A lot of other OSes are floating around as well. Samsung launched the bada OS with their Wave smartphone. Nokia introduced the Maemo with the N900. We should be seeing Meego devices very soon. Now that HP has truly taken over Palm, the WebOS development is in full swing.



For those who indulge

### The 2010 story

**Apple iOS4:** The new OS from Apple was synced with the launch of the iPhone 4. Since Apple develops the software as well as the hardware, the entire combination is completely optimised for the end user to enjoy. This was the first platform which streamlined and popularized the concept of apps, by bringing them under one roof. The App Store currently has 300,000 applications available for download.

**Google's Android:** Currently, there are phones which run the old 1.5, 1.6, 2.0, 2.1 and the latest 2.2 versions of the OS. Android 2.3 will be arriving in phones very soon. However, the next major update will be seen later this year when Android 3.0 arrives. Not only will there be major visual and feature upgrades, but tablet devices will finally see an 'optimized' OS. Over 1,00,000 apps available for download via the Android Market. The Android Market can only be accessed via the handset, unlike the Apple App Store which can also be accessed on the PC. However, the most

important thing here was the fact that Google allowed handset manufacturers to customize the OS according to their phones. Hence, we saw the evolution of 'skins' like the HTC Sense offering a customized look and functionality over and above the Android OS. HTC, Motorola, Samsung, LG and even handset makers like Micromax are churning out new Android phone launches by the dozen. And yes, Google's Andy Rubin responded to Apple's announcement regarding daily iPhone activations with his own bombshell, 3,00,000 Android phones get activated daily.

**Blackberry OS6:** The final word for the business user. Blackberry's operating system offered everything which a business user wanted- mails, IMs, documents and messages in one phone. The QWERTY keypad made it popular with the 'serious' user. The new OS6 update brings in a lot of visual as well as feature improvements allowing it to keep pace with the iOS4, Android and even Symbian3, to a certain extent. The Blackberry Torch is their first OS6 handset. However, older handsets like the Curve 3G, Bold 9700 and even some Curve series handsets will get the OS6 upgrade.

**Symbian3:** Nokia was criticised for still flogging the almost dead Symbian S60 operating system for smartphones. However, the much anticipated Sym-